

•The Plain Dealer | Friday, March 19, 2004

Sports | •D9

BOYS REGIONAL BASKETBALL SEMIFINALS

DIVISION I

Even after defeat, Rhodes has plenty to celebrate

MIKE PETICCA
Plain Dealer Reporter

TOLEDO — Rhodes coach Keith Schofield would have preferred a victory in the Rams' big game on Thursday night. He did not consider defeat, though, a lost cause.

"We will have no remorse on the bus ride back," Schofield said after Rhodes lost, 60-47, to Toledo St. John's in a Division I regional semifinal game. "We are going to rejoice in the season we had. I think the 2½-hour drive back will be a special one. The young men will have some time to reflect on what they accom-

plished."

Point guard Brian Roberts scored 18 points and dished eight assists for St. John's (21-4). The Titans will play Olmsted Falls (22-2) on Saturday night in Savage Hall for the regional title and a trip to the state's final four.

"They're a good team," Roberts said of Olmsted Falls. "They shoot the basketball and they have good athletes. It should be a tough game for us."

"Jumpin' Joe Roberts, Rhodes' 6-4 guard and the Senate Athletic League MVP, scored 15 points. Phil Moore, a 6-8 senior center, had nine points and eight re-

bounds, but the Rams were held to 37 percent shooting from the field.

Yet, it was a breakthrough season for the Rams. The Senate champions defeated Collinwood twice and Glenville once, and victories over St. Ignatius and Strongsville earned them their first district championship in 36 years.

"I don't think you have enough paper to talk about how significant the season has been," Schofield said. "Rhodes hasn't been a premier power, not even in the city of Cleveland. It was great to have a group of seniors like Joe

Roberts. I told our young kids in the locker room that we now have a tradition to build on."

The Rams stayed in the game by forcing 17 St. John's turnovers, the bulk of the Titans' mistakes coming against Rhodes' trapping zone defenses. When St. John's got a shot off, though, it usually hit it. The Titans were 26-of-45 (58 percent) from the field. They made 14 layups, most of them when Rhodes was in its man-to-man defense.

St. John's led, 50-36, with three minutes left in the third quarter. The Rams, though, forced a flurry of Titans' turn-

overs and cut the St. John's lead to 53-46 with 4:50 to go. Moore began the 10-3 Rhodes run with a 3-point play. Joe Roberts then hit a short baseline jumper and scored twice off offensive rebounds.

The Titans regained control of the game with their 2-3 zone defense. Rhodes scored one point in its final eight possessions.

"We were trying to get up on their shooters and give help on their other guys," St. John's coach Ed Heintschel said.

The game was the 11th played in Savage Hall for St. John's.

"I wish we didn't have to travel

24 hours by bus to get here," Schofield said. "It makes it easier to play if this is your home court. . . . It's tough for 16- and 17-year-old kids to travel like that. Maybe the bus ride takes away the kids' legs and their concentration a little."

B.J. Raymond, a 6-6 junior forward, and 6-7 junior center Zach Hillebrand give St. John's one of Ohio's premier big-man combinations. They combined for 21 points on 10-of-19 shooting and grabbed 14 rebounds.

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DIVISION I

Patience is the key

Experienced Railroaders keep Bearcats at bay

EDDIE DWYER
Plain Dealer Reporter

No one needed to remind the Collinwood Railroaders what they were playing for Thursday night.

"We talked about it all week," said all-district junior forward Jason Simon. "We wanted to come out, play hard and play our game, so we could take it even further."

Collinwood's game, both in the half court and the open court, has the team from the city's Senate Athletic League making history.

The Railroaders, competing in "Sweet 16" play for the first time, turned away a young and talented Bedford squad, 69-54, in a boys basketball Division I regional semifinal at the University of Akron's James A. Rhodes Arena.

Collinwood (21-3), which controlled the first and fourth quarters, advanced to Saturday's 7:30 p.m. regional championship game at Rhodes Arena. The opponent will be the tradition-rich Canton McKinley Bulldogs (21-3), who are competing in regional play for the 47th time.

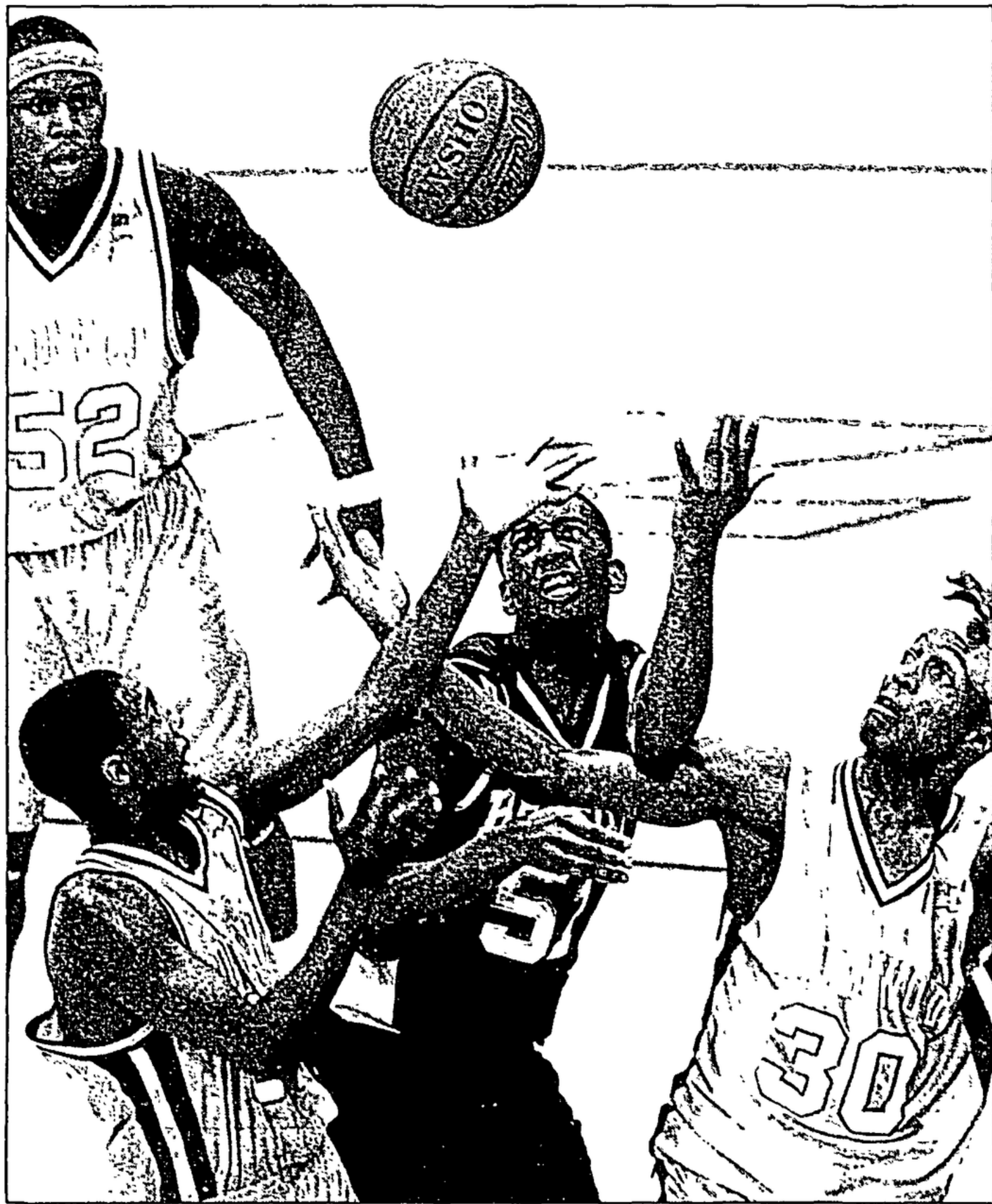
"We were definitely afraid of Bedford's speed and how they get the ball off the glass and get it up the floor in transition," said Railroaders coach Ken Vana. "I thought our transition defense, for the most part, was pretty good."

"But let me give my assistant, Louie Moore, some credit. He said during a timeout, 'Coach, we can beat them down the floor. Let's get it out and let's be aggressive.'"

Collinwood's versatility on offense and senior leadership on defense definitely wore on the sophomore-laden Bearcats.

Showing patience in the half court against Bedford's zone defense, the Railroaders rode the hot hand of All-Senate senior guard Stacy Sorrell to a 27-19 halftime lead. Sorrell scored 12 of his 17 points in the first 16 minutes by hitting four 3-pointers.

The Bearcats (14-10), Ohio's Division I state runner-up in 2000, switched to a man-to-man defense in the third quarter and, on the strength of a buzzer-beating 3-pointer by sophomore guard Brandon Pitts, cut an 11-point deficit to 43-36 entering the final eight minutes. Preventing the team from the Lake Erie League from doing further damage



ROADELL HICKMAN / THE PLAIN DEALER

Collinwood's Jason Simon, front left, Raynold Mitchell (52) and Jeremy Weaver surround Bedford's Marlon Leek as they all scramble for a rebound during the Railroaders' regional semifinal victory Thursday night in Akron.

At University of Akron

Wednesday: Canton McKinley 77, Medina 51

Thursday: Collinwood 69, Bedford 54

Saturday: Championship, 7:30.

in the quarter was Simon, who scored 11 of his game-high 20 points in the third quarter.

With Collinwood's standout senior post Raynold Mitchell on the bench with four fouls, Bedford was able to get some second shots and draw fouls. The Bearcats closed to 47-44 with 5:24 left on two free throws each by sophomore guards Anthony Lumpkin and Charles Osby.

"Whoever the fifth man was coming off the bench, we all had to step up and just keep attacking the glass at that point," said Railroaders all-district senior forward Jeremy

Weaver.

Collinwood did just that after Mitchell was whistled for his fifth foul with 4:50 remaining.

With senior guard Bryant Fluker, Weaver and Mitchell's replacement, 6-5 junior Darnell Campbell, all hitting clutch free throws, and Weaver coming up with an acrobatic follow off the glass, the Railroaders responded with a 7-0 run and held a 10-point lead with 3:20 to go. They took command on a jumper by Simon, a layup, an offensive rebound and two free throws by Campbell, and a driving one-hander by Sorrell.

"We never got into an offensive flow," said Bedford's veteran coach Everett Heard. "Collinwood showed great patience against our zone. But we really couldn't follow the game plan, which was trying to get the ball inside."

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DIVISION I

Persistent press seals Bulldogs win

TIM ROGERS
Plain Dealer Reporter

TOLEDO — You want offense? Olmsted Falls can produce offense from several different sources, as it has proved numerous times during the season.

But it was the Bulldogs' pressing defense that produced their biggest victory of the season Thursday, a 68-57 win over Mansfield in a Division I regional semifinal in front of about 5,000 fans in Savage Hall.

The victory means Olmsted Falls (22-2) will play in its first regional title game since 1997 on Saturday when it takes on Toledo St. John's in Savage Hall at 7:30 p.m. St. John's will be playing in the University of Toledo arena for the 11th time this season.

"Beating the press has been our Achilles' heel all season," said Mansfield coach Gregg Collins. "We've had trouble with pressure all season, times when we've had leads that we were unable to preserve, and it ended up costing us."

It happened again Thursday when the Tygers simply couldn't handle the Bulldogs' relentless press.

Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue was asked if the press, which helped produce the majority of Mansfield's 19 turnovers, was something his team had been working on.

"Yeah, we've been pressing for five years, six years," Donahue deadpanned. "So, yeah, we've been working on it a lot."

"In all honesty, it was something we had in our scouting report. We felt we could get them to turn the ball over a little bit if we pressed the court way."

The Bulldogs scored 21 points off those turnovers, many coming from easy shots after a steal in the Tygers' backcourt.

Still, the Bulldogs had the offense in gear, as well, as their Big Three — Steve Gansey, Dan Binggeli and Jamar Scales — all scored in double figures. The

At University of Toledo

Thursday: Olmsted Falls 68, Mansfield 57
Toledo St. John's 60, Rhodes 47
Saturday: Championship, 7:30

team shot 46 percent from the field and made 14 of 22 free throws.

Reaching the regional finals — and perhaps beyond — has been a dream of Gansey and Binggeli since they began their high school careers four years ago.

"We've been playing together since the seventh or eighth grade, and ever since we were in high school all we talked about was going to Columbus, or going as far as we could go," said Gansey.

Scales, a 6-3 senior who transferred to Olmsted Falls a few years ago, was nearly unstoppable the first half and finished with 24 points, eight rebounds, four steals and two assists.

Gansey, a 6-2 guard, scored 21 points and had five rebounds. Binggeli, a 6-3 guard, finished with 19 points, three rebounds, two assists and four steals.

Mansfield (17-7) got 16 points from senior Marquis Carter and 14 from 6-6 senior Yima Chiuva-Kur. Despite pulling down a whopping 42 rebounds — 17 on the offensive end — the Tygers failed to capitalize. They scored 12 second-chance points.

Gansey made what probably was the biggest shot of the game with 2:51 remaining and the Bulldogs protecting a 61-53 lead. Finding he had space, he launched a 3-point shot that boosted the lead to 11.

"I'm no stranger to shooting the 3-pointer," Gansey smiled. "The guy was playing off me a little bit, so I just shot it."

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HIGH SCHOOL SCOREBOARD

GIRLS BASKETBALL

State semifinals

Division III

Yonkers (25-2) — Dickinson 49

2-10, Davidson 64-17-16, Grant 4-19-66

15, Slaters 7-9 3-17, Bennett 0-1 0-0

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